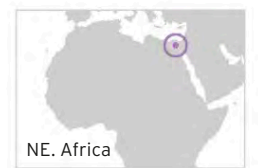




Pyramids of Giza

Astonishing feats of engineering and imagination that have become monuments to a remarkable ancient civilization



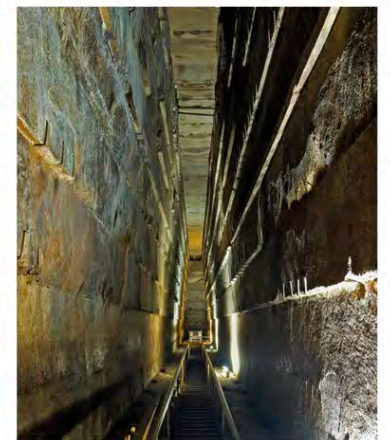
The pyramids at Giza on the west bank of the Nile are among the world's most familiar landmarks. They include the Great Pyramid, which was one of the Seven Wonders of the Ancient World. Tremendous feats of engineering, craftsmanship, and labor, they are thought to have been built during Khufu's reign (c.2545–2525 BCE). The massive pyramid complexes included burial chambers for the kings and queens, mortuary temples, valley temples, and connecting causeways. More than just royal burial tombs, the pyramids housed all the items that the pharaohs would need to ensure their comfort in the afterlife, in the belief that after death they would achieve immortality and divine status. Full-sized boats were buried near the pyramids as transport for the pharaoh in the afterlife.

Ramps to the sky

The oldest and largest of Giza's three main pyramids is Khufu's Great Pyramid, which rose to a height of 480 ft (146 m), with a base width of 755 ft (230 m). The colossal

structure contained around 92 million cubic ft (2.3 million cubic m) of stone blocks, which were arranged with astonishing precision. The core of the pyramid is made of yellowish limestone and was originally surfaced with smooth, white Tura limestone. (This was later removed to build mosques.)

The second, smaller, pyramid at Giza is 471 ft (144 m) high and was built by Khufu's son, Khafre. The third pyramid, built by Menkaure and unfinished at the time of his death, is the smallest of the three (about 213 ft/65 m in height) but has a more complex mortuary temple. These tombs have immense religious and mythic significance and symbolize not only ancient Egypt's veneration of the dead, but also the might of the pharaoh and the centrality of the Sun god Ra. The pyramid's triangular shape, for example, is often said to derive from the belief that, following the death of a pharaoh, the Sun god would intensify his rays, creating a ramp on which the spirit of the deceased could easily ascend to the sky.



△ KHUFU'S GRAND GALLERY

This spectacular corbel-roofed passageway known as the Grand Gallery, inside the Great Pyramid, leads to Khufu's burial chamber, which contained his mummified corpse.